International Journal of Hospitality Management 126 (2025) 104110



Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

International Journal of Hospitality Management

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/ijhm





The contribution of sustainable practices to the creation of memorable customer experience: Empirical evidence from Michelin Green Star restaurants

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:
Memorable customer experience
Sustainable practices
Michelin Green Star restaurants
Upscale restaurant
Dining experience
Luxury restaurant

ABSTRACT

This study aims to examine the contribution of sustainable practices to the creation of memorable customer experiences (CXs) in upscale restaurants, especially Michelin Green Star Restaurants (MGSRs). This research adopts a qualitative approach, employing the Gioia methodology to analyze the interviews with MGSRs' managers and chefs, as well as the content of the restaurants' corporate websites. In the findings, we identify the sustainable practices adopted by MGSRs to enhance CX memorability and classify them based on the theoretical dimensions of the hospitality experience. Finally, we propose a framework that integrates the sustainable practices implemented by MGSRs within the dimensions of functionality, authenticity, emotionality, engagement, and expressivity in hospitality CX. In this circular process, the partnerships developed among local suppliers, chefs, staff, and customers play a fundamental role in creating memorable CXs. This study combines and extends the literature on CX memorability and sustainable practices in upscale restaurants and provides practical suggestions to restaurant managers.

1. Introduction

In an ever-challenging hospitality context, providing customers with product and service quality is insufficient to gain a competitive advantage (Gilmore and Pine, 2002; Maklan and Klaus, 2011). One key objective in the contemporary hospitality industry is creating memorable customer experiences (CXs) (Hwang and Seo, 2016; Kim and Ritchie, 2014; McColl et al., 2022; Angeloni, 2023). Experiences become memorable when they are positively or negatively (Stone and Sthapit, 2024) recalled and reflected upon (Kim, 2018). To create such experiences, hospitality businesses are investing in meeting and delighting – i.e., exceeding – the customers' needs and expectations (Barnes and Krallman, 2019; Kim, 2014; Torres et al., 2020) by acting at sensorial, emotional, cognitive, behavioral, and relational levels (e.g., Ariffin and Maghzi, 2012; Chandralal and Valenzuela, 2013; Ben Lahouel and Montargot, 2020).

The dining experience has a fundamental role in the tourist experience (e.g., Akhoondnejad et al., 2022), is a motivation to travel (Akhoondnejad, 2024) and return (Kivela and Crotts, 2006), as well as an important factor able to influence destination choice (Dixit and Prayag, 2022). Expectations regarding the dining experience are particularly high towards upscale restaurants such as Michelin-starred restaurants, which offer sophisticated menus in an elegant and well-designed atmosphere to generate pleasure and emotions and communicate a specific style and quality of life (Ha and Jang, 2013; Khan, 2020; Tsaur and Lo, 2020), as well as stir curiosity (Şahin et al., 2021). Customers of this type of restaurant can be both tourists and locals who desire to enjoy pleasant and unique gastronomic experiences that create memories for a long time, such as learning or tasting something new about food and local culture to share with family and friends (e.g., Björk and Kauppinen-Räisänen, 2017). In this experiential setting, starred chefs play a fundamental role through their constant pursuit of quality, creativity, innovative ideas, and authentic identity, striving to meet customers' growing needs for both functional and hedonic value (Batat, 2021; Kiatkawsin and Han, 2019). Once exclusive to the élite, Michelin-starred restaurants have progressively attracted a more diverse clientele. This shift is partly due to the influence of the many culinary programs and competitions showcased on television and social media,

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https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ijhm.2025.104110
Received 2 May 2024; Received in revised form 13 December 2024; Accepted 8 January 2025
Available online 11 January 2025
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which significantly inspire customers to enjoy experiences in luxury gastronomic restaurants (Andrieu and Batat, 2019).

Previous studies have highlighted the importance of investing in different elements to create memorable CXs. With specific reference to upscale restaurants, food, service, physical environment quality (e.g., Bonfanti et al., 2023; Hoang and Suleri, 2021), and technology (Ma et al., 2023; Suarez et al., 2019) are fundamental elements of memorable CX. Providing customers with an experience-oriented offering is crucial for business competitiveness because restaurants can differentiate their products, develop positive word-of-mouth, and cultivate a positive reputation by increasing customer loyalty (Shaw and Ivens, 2005; Souki et al., 2023).

Furthermore, upscale restaurants invest in sustainability to gain further competitive advantage. In this regard, some studies have examined different aspects of sustainable practices, such as restaurateurs' passion for a more sustainable cuisine (Enthoven and Brouwer, 2019), the sustainable reputation of the Michelin Restaurant Guide (Kiatkawsin and Sutherland, 2020), and the adoption of green practices by restaurants (Madanaguli et al., 2022; Raab et al., 2018; Riva et al., 2022; Tasca et al., 2022), particularly in Michelin Green Star Restaurants (MGSRs) (Huang et al., 2023). The importance of exploring sustainability in upscale dining establishments (Athwal et al., 2019; Batat, 2020; Huang and Hall, 2023), as well as the intricate coexistence of sustainability with luxury restaurant experiences (Batat, 2021; Hartmann et al., 2016), has been addressed in the literature. While tourism and hospitality literature highlights the strategic role of memorable CXs and sustainability to create potential competitive advantages (Azevedo, 2010; Hanna et al., 2018), little is known about their practical link in hospitality literature. Previous studies highlighted how to stimulate sustainable CX (e.g., Signori et al., 2019), how environmental sustainability can be integrated into the CX (e.g., Calza et al., 2023; Moliner et al., 2019), and how long-term collaboration amongst different stakeholders can contribute to creating an environmentally sustainable CX (Mihardjo et al., 2019). To the best of the authors' knowledge, no studies have hitherto covered the following research question: *What sustainable business practices do green upscale restaurants adopt to create memorable CXs?*

This study aims to fill this research gap by investigating sustainable business practices that upscale restaurant managers adopt to create memorable CXs. Specifically, it identifies the sustainable practices adopted by MGSRs to improve the memorability of CX, classifies these practices based on the theoretical dimensions of the hospitality experience, and proposes a conceptual model for creating memorable CXs through sustainable practices. Because of the exploratory nature of this research, a qualitative methodology was used: in-depth semi-structured interviews with managers of MGSRs worldwide and the Gioia methodology were employed to collect and analyze data (Gioia et al., 2013).

This research contributes to the literature on the hospitality industry, especially in upscale restaurants, by enriching memorable CX design theory through a conceptual model that highlights sustainable business practices that create memorable CX. In addition, practical recommendations are provided for restaurant managers to continue to compete successfully.

This study is organized as follows. After reviewing previous research on memorable CX and sustainable business practices in restaurants, the methodological approach is described, and the results are presented and discussed. Next, the theoretical and practical implications are proposed. Finally, this study concludes with the limitations and future research directions.

2. Literature review

2.1. Memorable customer experience in restaurants

Pine and Gilmore (1999) emphasize that hospitality firms offer customers not just products and services but also experiences. Lemon and Verhoef (2016, p.70) suggest that CX is "the aggregation of a customer's cognitive, emotional, behavioral, sensory, and social responses to a company's offerings throughout the purchase journey." Using the metaphor of theatre, "an experience occurs when a company intentionally uses services as the stage, and goods as props, to engage individual customers in a way that creates a memorable event" (Pine and Gilmore, 1998, p. 98). Multiple studies emphasize the close connection between experience and memorability (Hosany et al., 2022; Hwang and Seo, 2016; Kim et al., 2012), which takes place when experiences are emotionally remembered (Piqueras-Fiszman and Jaeger, 2015) and recalled (Kim, 2018).

In practical terms, creating a memorable CX has become an essential strategic objective in the hospitality industry (e.g., Ali et al., 2014; Kandampully et al., 2014; Prentice et al., 2022; Tsaur et al., 2023; Souki et al., 2023). Hospitality firms can provide customers with high-quality, extraordinary, and unforgettable experiences that are the core of a highly competitive advantage (Cao et al., 2019; Kim et al., 2012). To facilitate the creation of memorable CX, hospitality firms can propose an unparalleled atmosphere (Türker et al., 2019) by emphasizing servicescape attributes (Souki et al., 2023). In addition, they can develop innovative service offerings by creating value through both technological and non-technological innovations (Tsaur et al., 2024). They can integrate the dimensions of functionality, authenticity, emotionality, and engagement in the service innovation system by equipping the firm with spirit, culture, values, and character, that is, organizational personality, to create the "soul of the hospitality experience" (Kandampully et al., 2023, p. 166).

Regarding the restaurant industry, restaurateurs invest in different servicescape elements to provide customers with unique, positive, and memorable experiences (Fernandes et al., 2015). Given that the more an experience involves the customer, the more exciting and memorable it tends to be (Pine and Gilmore, 1998), restaurateurs create specific environmental conditions to arouse customers' emotions, which are a key component of memorable experience (Bastiaansen et al., 2019; Horng and Hsu, 2021; Lin, 2022; Souki et al., 2023). In addition to being characterized by high-intensity emotions (Goolaup et al., 2018), memorability is further aroused by tangible and intangible perceived quality factors (Cao et al., 2019; Türker et al., 2019; Lin et al., 2022; Souki et al., 2023) such as creative food display (Teng and Chen, 2023). Akhoondnejad et al. (2024, p. 4) also suggest that the memorability of food experience is influenced by situated involvement, i.e., "on-site, real-time and in-the-moment involvement which refers to an unobservable state of motivation, arousal or interest towards an experience which is evoked by the factors during the experience".

Upscale restaurants (e.g., Michelin-starred) place memorability at the center of their core business (Emenheiser et al., 1998). As emphasized by Batat (2021), upscale restaurants focus on establishing lasting memories through exclusive and extraordinary dining encounters, which are based on high-quality and food safety (e.g., Lee and Hwang, 2011; Ha and Jang, 2013), combined with a unique style, graceful and elegant atmosphere, and service differentiating from other dining establishments (Khan, 2020). Since customers frequently choose these restaurants for special occasions (Cao et al., 2019; Tsaur and Lo, 2020), upscale restaurants provide them with pleasure, excitement, sophistication, values regarding the quality of life, an elegant and refined ambiance, and elaborate menus (Khan, 2020; Ha and Jang, 2013). Chefs consistently pursue excellence and creativity and deliver distinctive culinary and service experiences to customers while preserving the cultural heritage of a place in their gastronomic offer (Batat, 2021). Therefore, providing customers with an experience-oriented offering has become crucial (Bonfanti et al., 2023; Kandampully et al., 2023).

A few scholars examined sustainable CX as a source of competitive advantage (e.g., Mihardjo et al., 2019; Signori et al., 2019). Others explored how to integrate environmental sustainability into the CX (e.g., Calza et al., 2023; Moliner et al., 2019). However, to the best of our knowledge, no studies have addressed the contribution of sustainable

practices to creating memorable CX within upscale restaurants.

2.2. Sustainable practices in restaurants

Multiple scholars highlight the adverse impact of restaurants on the environment (e.g., Chiang and Sheu, 2020; Fieschi and Pretato, 2018; Filimonau et al., 2020). A recent study classifies and synthesizes the literature addressing environmental unsustainability problems in the restaurant industry (Madanaguli et al., 2022) by revealing food and plastic waste, emissions, and inefficient utilization of energy and water as primary sources of environmental unsustainability in this industry. At the same time, several studies argue that restaurants are increasingly becoming aware of their adverse impact on the environment (e.g., Sakaguchi et al., 2018) and are integrating sustainability into their management practices (Huang et al., 2023; Namkung and Jang, 2017). Sustainable practice is "business behavior that leads to a net overall increase in the different forms of capital associated with sustainable development" (Moser, 2001, p. 293). These practices can cover the following dimensions: water efficiency, waste reduction and recycling, sustainable furnishings and building materials, sustainable food, and reducing energy, waste, chemicals, and pollution (Namkung and Jang, 2017).

With specific reference to upscale restaurants, Michelin-starred restaurants have carved out a distinctive niche by adopting unique approaches to food product handling, setting themselves apart from more traditional establishments (Huang et al., 2023). These prestigious venues are committed to ethical and local sourcing within the food system, a practice that enhances several operational facets (Chabert-Rios and Deale, 2016). According to Charlebois et al. (2015), the benefits of such practices include a preliminary evaluation of products by local suppliers, shortened delivery times, accurate quantity fulfillment, maintained product integrity, and improved cost efficiency. Another sustainable practice in Michelin-starred restaurants is establishing a direct market connection with local farmers and suppliers (Brinkley et al., 2021). When sustainable practices in Michelin-starred restaurants are integrated throughout the procurement, preparation, and presentation processes and aligned with the location, they effectively embody the three pillars of sustainability (Huang and Hall, 2023). This approach fosters sustainable agriculture and preserves ethno-culinary traditions by strengthening the restaurants' connections to local communities (Chin and Musa, 2021).

The adoption of sustainable business practices in restaurants enhances organizational legitimacy and, at the same time, increases competitive advantage. In this regard, developing a green identity and promoting a sense of responsibility within upscale restaurants correlate positively with enhanced financial performance (Hwang et al., 2020) and an improved green image (Namkung and Jang, 2017). Customers prefer food that is not only healthy but also environmentally sustainable (Jang et al., 2015) and show an inclination toward environmentally conscious choices, thus prioritizing the consumption of emission-free food when informed about its origin (Wen et al., 2020). In other words, they reward restaurants that adopt sustainable practices by identifying them as providers of distinctive values.

Multiple studies thus investigate sustainable practices in the restaurant industry, including Michelin-starred restaurants. However, they still have not addressed the link between these practices and the memorable CX design. Therefore, this study investigates how sustainable practices can contribute to creating memorable CX in the MGSRs.

3. Methodology

3.1. Research design

Given the explorative nature of this research and the limited knowledge of the issue under investigation, this study adopts a qualitative methodology as a research design strategy. It is suitable for purposes of this research for several reasons. First, it enables the exploration of a specific and complex phenomenon in its real-life context (Yin, 2017), such as the contribution of sustainable practices to creating memorable CX in MGSRs. Second, exploratory studies in qualitative research are suitable to address emerging topics for which existing theories and frameworks may not fully explain the phenomenon under investigation (Creswell and Poth, 2016). Third, it is considered a suitable method to address "what" type research questions (What sustainable business practices do green upscale restaurants adopt to create memorable CXs?), considering that the study is limited to a specific context (MGSRs) and the events examined are contemporary (Yin, 2015). Finally, it allows the collection of rich data in their natural state without manipulation or intervention during the process (Corbin and Strauss, 2015) and the exploration of dynamics and emerging practices to develop further research (Eisenhardt, 1989).

An abductive approach was employed because it enables researchers to move iteratively between theory and empirical data to grasp the phenomenon better (Dubois and Gadde, 2014).

Data was collected from primary and secondary sources to understand the phenomenon under study. Following Rubin and Rubin's (2011) recommendations, we opted for semi-structured in-depth interviews as the data collection method of primary sources. The interviews were specially conducted with MGSRs' owners, managers, and chefs, given their functional role in revealing supplementary viewpoints, ideas, and encounters associated with the phenomenon of interest for this study that has not been previously investigated in the literature. Using multiple observers as data sources serves to overcome single-source bias and increase the validity of results (Jack and Raturi, 2006). In-depth interviews were chosen because they give informants freedom and flexibility to communicate their ideas, beliefs, and experiences in their own words and use storytelling to converse relaxedly (Creswell and Creswell, 2018). Before initiating interviews with MGSRs, a review phase engaged two professors specializing in CX management and two managers from the upscale restaurant industry. The purpose was to confirm the clarity and explicit wording of the questions. The experts were briefed on the study's objective to gain deeper insights into how MGSRs enhance memorable CX through sustainability initiatives. Their suggestions were included in the final version. Additionally, interview questions underwent pre-testing on the Google Meet platform for improved usability, with the participation of two MGSRs' managers in the sample. Since no significant revisions were recommended, the responses collected during the pre-test phase were included in the final data corpus.

The interview guide was designed based on the literature review on CX, memorable CX, and sustainable practices of MGSRs. The following two topics constitute the core of the interview: (1) actions of memorable CX creation and (2) sustainable practices undertaken by MGSRs to create memorable CX. To gather a comprehensive range of information, the general topics mentioned were formulated in an open-ended question format (Gioia et al., 2013). Specifically, the interview guide questions were as follows:

1. What is the job title of the interviewee?
2. In which year did the restaurant acquire the Green Star from Michelin?
3. Does the restaurant design and implement actions to create a memorable CX? If yes, what are those actions? Please share some examples.
4. What sustainable actions does the restaurant adopt to create memorable CXs? Please provide specific examples.
5. How is the restaurant organized to implement all these actions?

Furthermore, this study triangulates data with secondary sources to enhance research validity and reliability (Yin, 2017). The final information for all restaurants is supplemented with data from the restaurants' websites, as also suggested by the respondents during the

interviews. Thus, the final dataset comprises direct interviews with MGSRs and information from corporate websites. Fig. 1 summarizes the research steps in detail.

3.2. Research context

To address the research question ("What sustainable business practices do green upscale restaurants adopt to create memorable CXs?"), this study delves into the context of MGSRs, emphasizing the Michelin 'Green Star' as a significant award for a restaurant's commitment to sustainability (Huang and Hall, 2023; Michelin Guide, 2024). The 'green star' was introduced in 2020 in response to the increased commitment of Michelin-starred restaurants to community and individual well-being (Batat, 2020; Hall and Gössling, 2016; Huang and Hall, 2023), with a strong emphasis on ecological responsibility and excellence. Thus, Green Star is awarded to restaurants that stand out for minimizing waste and reducing or eliminating plastic and other non-recyclable materials from their supply chain, hence actively mitigating their environmental impact (Michelin Guide, 2024). The revised Michelin Guide, 2024 awarded the Green Star to 498 out of 16,907 Michelin-starred restaurants worldwide. This trend directly responds to shifting consumer preferences, driven by increased awareness of environmental and health concerns (Jang et al., 2015).

3.3. Sampling procedure and data collection

A purposeful sampling method was employed for this study, starting with the official Michelin Guide website, renowned as a leading authority in the food and beverage industry and providing comprehensive restaurant reviews worldwide. Based on the two different criteria of homogeneity (limited to Michelin-starred restaurants with 'Green star" only) and heterogeneity (number of Michelin stars and country), the sample of 498 MGSRs was selected to ensure theoretical diversity. Email contacts for these restaurants were derived from their official websites. The data collection process comprised three phases: 1) sending email invitations to the 498 selected restaurants, 2) identifying the respondents, and 3) conducting the interviews. This study collected the active participation of 19 respondents (Table 1 shows their profiles with names that are kept confidential). This number of interviews conducted is appropriate, adhering to the recommended threshold for qualitative research, particularly in exploratory research approaches (e.g., Creswell, 2007) and among homogenous populations such as MGSRs (e.g., Saunders, 2012).

Before starting each interview, participants were asked for permission to record the interview for academic purposes only. Due to geographic disparities, interviews were conducted via Google Meet between November 2023 and February 2024. The interview sessions lasted

Table 1
Profile of the sample.

Restaurant	Michelin stars	Michelin Green Star	Respondents' job title	Country
R1	✿	✿	Head chef	Italy
R2	✿	✿	Restaurant manager	Italy
R3	✿	✿	Owner and executive chef	USA
R4	✿	✿	Owner and executive chef	Japan
R5	✿	✿	Executive Assistant	France
R6	✿	✿	Co-owner and executive chef	Belgium
R7	✿	✿	Head chef	Portugal
R8	✿	✿	Head chef	Spain
R9	✿	✿	Owner	Switzerland
R10	✿	✿	Owner and executive chef	Netherlands
R11	✿	✿	Owner	USA
R12	✿	✿	Restaurant manager and chef	Switzerland
R13	✿	✿	Manager communications	Norway
R14	✿	✿	Owner	Germany
R15	✿	✿	Restaurant manager	Deutschland
R16	✿	✿	Executive manager	Germany
R17	✿	✿	Restaurant manager and chef	Hungary
R18	✿	✿	Restaurant manager	Switzerland
R19	✿	✿	Head chef	Spain

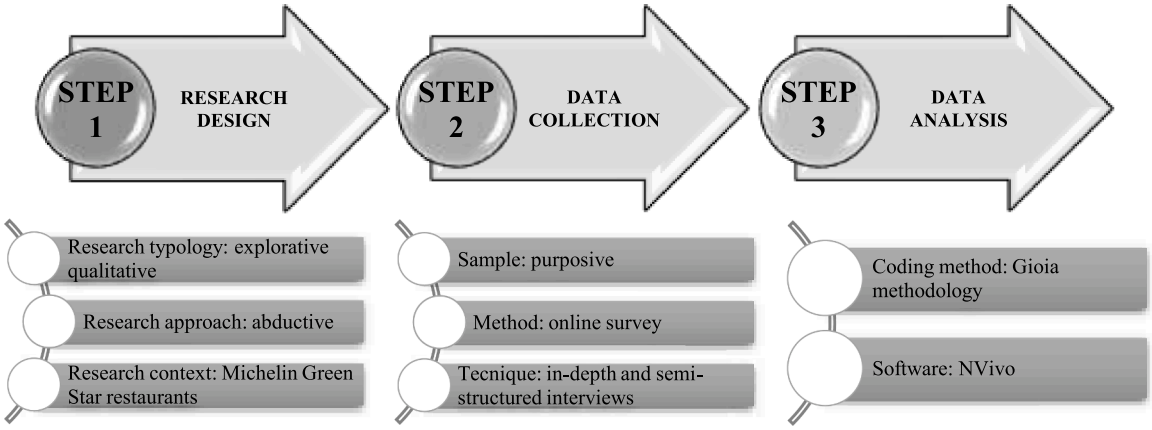


Fig. 1. Flow chart of the research process steps.

approximately 40 minutes to 1 hour and were conducted in both English and Italian, the latter exclusively for restaurants located in Italy. Following the approach outlined by Hogg et al. (2014), Italian-language interviews were translated into English. Without altering the obtained data, the proficiency of the researchers in both Italian and English languages, supported by a linguistics expert (Mcgorry, 2000), allowed us to translate the interview questions and participants' answers for reporting in the present study, thereby ensuring the accuracy and value of the translation.

3.4. Data analysis

The dataset – including interviews with MGSRs and information from the restaurants' websites – was analyzed using NVivo 12 software and reported in three stages outlined by Gioia et al. (2013), i.e., the first-order categories, second-order themes, and aggregate dimensions. Precisely, the first-order categories meticulously capture the details exhibited during the interviews with MGSRs. The second-order themes aggregate similar concepts found in the first-order categories. Finally, subsets of the second-order themes are gathered into theoretical aggregate dimensions.

This method was applied to identify and classify the sustainable business practices used by MGSRs to create memorable CXs. The researchers adopted a blended approach, inductively identifying the themes from the data and, subsequently, deductively framing these themes within the section of the framework proposed by Kandampully et al. (2023) regarding the hospitality experience dimensions. The number of codes progressed from 43 first-order concepts to 14 s-order themes to five aggregate dimensions. Fig. 2 provides an extract of the visual representation of the analytical procedure used. Specifically, it shows data structure regarding sustainable business practices aimed at creating a memorable CX according to the functionality dimension.

4. Findings

4.1. Sustainable business practices to create memorable CX in MGRSs

All the MGSRs considered for this study highlighted investing in memorable CX in multiple ways. Based on the Gioia methodology, this section presents the sustainable practices adopted by MGSRs that contribute to the memorability of CX for each of the dimensions theoretically identified by Kandampully et al. (2023), i.e., functionality, authenticity, emotionality, and engagement. In addition, the analysis shows that sustainable practices contribute to memorability through a new dimension of the CX not present in the original framework by Kandampully et al. (2023), i.e., expressivity. Table 2 shows these dimensions and sustainable business practices based on the frequency and identification number of the respondents. Some exemplary quotations are provided as empirical evidence to support the research findings.

4.1.1. The functionality dimension

In terms of functionality, the restaurateurs interviewed outlined the importance of providing customers with sustainable product quality:

> *"We refrain from using frozen raw materials and instead focus on seasonal foods that characterize our dishes in such a way that a multisensory dining experience is created by combining aesthetics with eco-consciousness, leaving a strong impression on customers."* (R16)

Furthermore, the tangible servicescape in which customers spend their time is crucial that it is sustainable, as exemplified in the following response:

> *"The atmosphere of our restaurant is designed to be pleasant, relaxing, and nature-filled. To this end, we have used sustainable building materials and created green spaces such as oriental gardens or green walls to immerse customers in nature."* (R4)

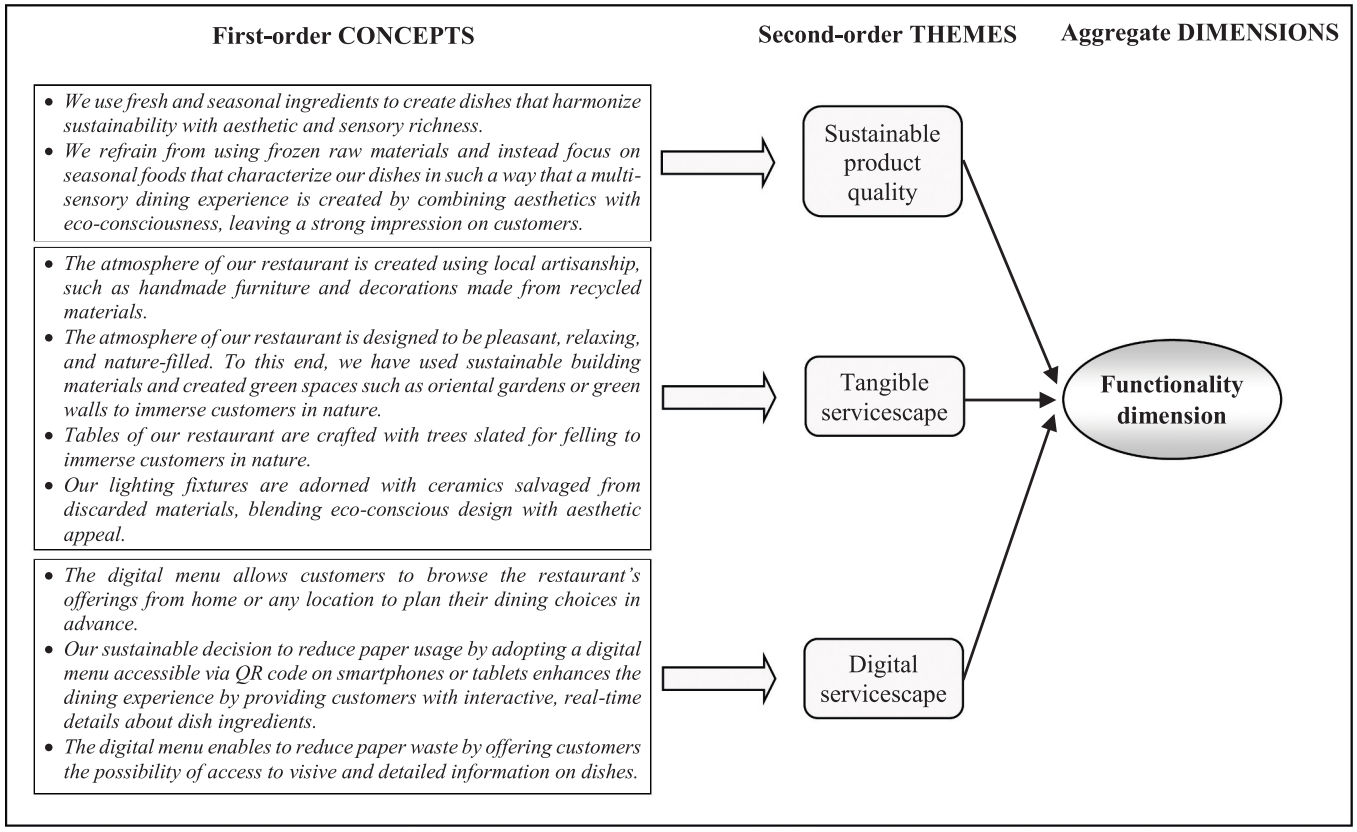


Fig. 2. An extract of data structure (sustainable business practices influencing the functionality dimension).

Table 2
Sustainable business practices to memorable customer experience creation in Michelin Green Star restaurants.

Experience-centric hospitality dimensions	Sustainable business practices	Frequency	Identification number of restaurant
The functionality dimension	• offering sustainable product quality • designing a tangible servicescape that is sustainable • making accessible and sustainable digital (e- and smart) servicescape	12	R1, R2, R3, R4, R6, R8, R11, R12, R16, R17, R18, R19
The authenticity dimension	• investing in sustainable food procurement by offering typical, local, and excellent products • creating embeddedness in the territory through local relationships within a network of suppliers • elaborating dishes based on tradition • developing circular economy practices	10	R1, R2, R3, R4, R6, R7, R16, R17, R18, R19
The emotionality dimension	• designing intangible elements of the servicescape • using food storytelling to narrate sustainable practices and arouse positive emotions	8	R1, R3, R4, R5, R13, R14, R18, R19
The engagement dimension	• implementing communication practices • introducing customer registration programs • offering initiatives for customer education about the origin of food	7	R1, R2, R5, R7, R8, R12, R18
The expressivity dimension	• generating a creative gastronomic journey • investing in sustainable servicescape creation	6	R8, R9, R10, R11, R15, R18

In addition to physical surroundings, the interviewees invest in digital servicescape, which includes e-servicescape (i.e., aesthetic, interactive, and navigable servicescape of the online context) and smart servicescape (i.e., interactions between customers and smart devices such as e-tablets or personal smartphones in the service environment) to make the reservation process and menu consultation more accessible and sustainable, as said in these responses:

> *"The digital menu allows customers to browse the restaurant's offerings from home or any location to plan their dining choices in advance."* (R1)

> *"Our sustainable decision to reduce paper usage by adopting a digital menu accessible via QR code on smartphones or tablets enhances the dining experience by providing customers with interactive, real-time details about dish ingredients."* (R12)

4.1.2. The authenticity dimension

In terms of authenticity, the restaurants examined provide their customers with typical and excellent products based on high-quality ingredients, the harmony of flavors, mastery of chefs' techniques, and their personalities in creating the entire menu. The restaurant managers highly invest in sustainable food procurement by choosing seasonal, locally sourced, and organically grown ingredients and providing an extensive range of natural and biodynamic beverages, as expressed in this interview excerpt:

> *"We prioritize sustainability by adopting botanical gastronomy with plant-based ingredients, embracing 100 % organic and biodynamic farming principles within a local radius, following 24 micro-seasons for a dynamic tasting menu, supporting fair coffee, chocolate, and sugar from small-scale farmers, featuring biodynamic and natural wines, and actively promoting artisanal spirits and beers from local microbreweries."* (R6)

These choices lead chefs to strong embeddedness in the territory, which develops through close relationships within a local network of suppliers that can provide local ingredients.

Another recurring theme that focuses on social sustainability is tradition, emphasized by chefs' ability to elaborate dishes using poor ingredients with modern techniques. In this regard, one of the respondents explained this:

> *"With an open kitchen, our customers have the chance to see the preparation of dishes and traditional culinary techniques passed down through generations."* (R17)

The integration of local traditions is often closely connected to the country's origins, as this interviewee revealed:

> *"We have some actions that can be thrilling for the customers: besides herbs sourced from nature, we also include daringly unusual - shall we say surprising - components in the dishes that are either long-forgotten elements of national cuisine or special innovations such as ants or burgundy snails."* (R18)

A few restaurants also developed circular economy practices to create unique, sustainable products based on local ingredients. For example, a restaurateur said:

> *"We use waste to create a welcome drink. We create juice pairings and kombuchas by using reused bottles that we use with our farm ingredients. We make a fermented beverage from our leftover bread called kvass. We produce knives for the main meat course from our 100-year-old olive tree roots."* (R7)

4.1.3. The emotionality dimension

Restaurateurs design intangible elements of servicescape in such a way as to emphasize the emotionality dimension of CX, generating an intimate and relaxing environment in which to spend a pleasant evening, as emerged from these interviews:

> *"We narrate the importance of each ingredient in the dish to guide customers during their dining experience. Each staff member is assigned to narrate relevant details according to their role throughout the customer's experience."* (R13)

With this regard, customers essentially search for - and appreciate - food storytelling not only by waitpersons but also by chefs, who often enter the dining room to tell them the culinary philosophy of the restaurant, creative practices used within dishes, and the journey of each ingredient from the local supplier to the dish. This excerpt from an interview exemplifies this commitment in terms of staff training to improve their storytelling skills:

> *"We prioritize the daily training of our staff, particularly those responsible for sharing the stories behind our dish's local ingredients. Our goal is for our staff to assist customers in understanding the origins of all-natural and local ingredients."* (R18)

4.1.4. The engagement dimension

Some sustainable practices play an important role in boosting the creation of customer engagement. Specifically, they implement various communication practices to engage their customers by emphasizing the sustainability of their offer regarding the food and servicescape. For example, food, genuineness, sustainability, and quality of (local and

organic) food are communicated through websites and menus, as this restaurateur said:

> *"On the website, our chef tells within the corporate videos the preparation of dishes to introduce customers to appreciate the gastronomic concept offered by our restaurant."* (R7)

In addition, multiple restaurateurs have introduced a customer registration program with consent, which allows them to capture customers' names, surnames, and preferences. This endeavor enhances service and guarantees that individual customers are acknowledged and served accordingly. This initiative is aimed at developing customer retention and loyalty, thereby enhancing engagement in terms of customer lifetime value and from an economic sustainability perspective, as highlighted in the following interview extract:

> *"Our customer loyalty program is designed to track our customers' visits, ensuring that upon their return, every detail of their preferences is remembered and prioritized by our attentive staff."* (R2)

Finally, restaurants try to improve engagement within the community by establishing a center that offers initiatives to educate children and adults about the origin of food, creating awareness among customers and the local community about the possibility of enjoying a sustainable dining experience.

4.1.5. The expressivity dimension

Customers enjoy an expressive experience through the culinary creations of chefs who generate a creative gastronomic journey with an excellent, complex, and never-obvious menu of great cultural content based on the conscious selection of the best products for creating seasonal and ethically sustainable dishes. In alignment with this perspective, restaurateurs have stated as follows:

> *"Our chef and kitchen staff conduct daily research and development to craft a distinctive culinary menu. Each dish is a manifestation of the chef's essence, expressed through the careful selection of raw ingredients."* (R14)

Expressivity is also reflected in the choice to invest in sustainable servicescape creation to communicate a coherent brand with their being an MGSR, as exemplified in the following extract:

> *"We take a conscious and stylish approach by outfitting our team in sustainable fashion uniforms crafted in collaboration with a sustainable fashion designer. This deliberate choice reflects our commitment to environmental responsibility and extends the ethos of our culinary offerings to the attire of our dedicated team. By embracing sustainable fashion, we aim to present a cohesive and genuine experience for our customers, where every aspect, from the menu to the team's uniforms, aligns with our values of sustainability."* (R8)

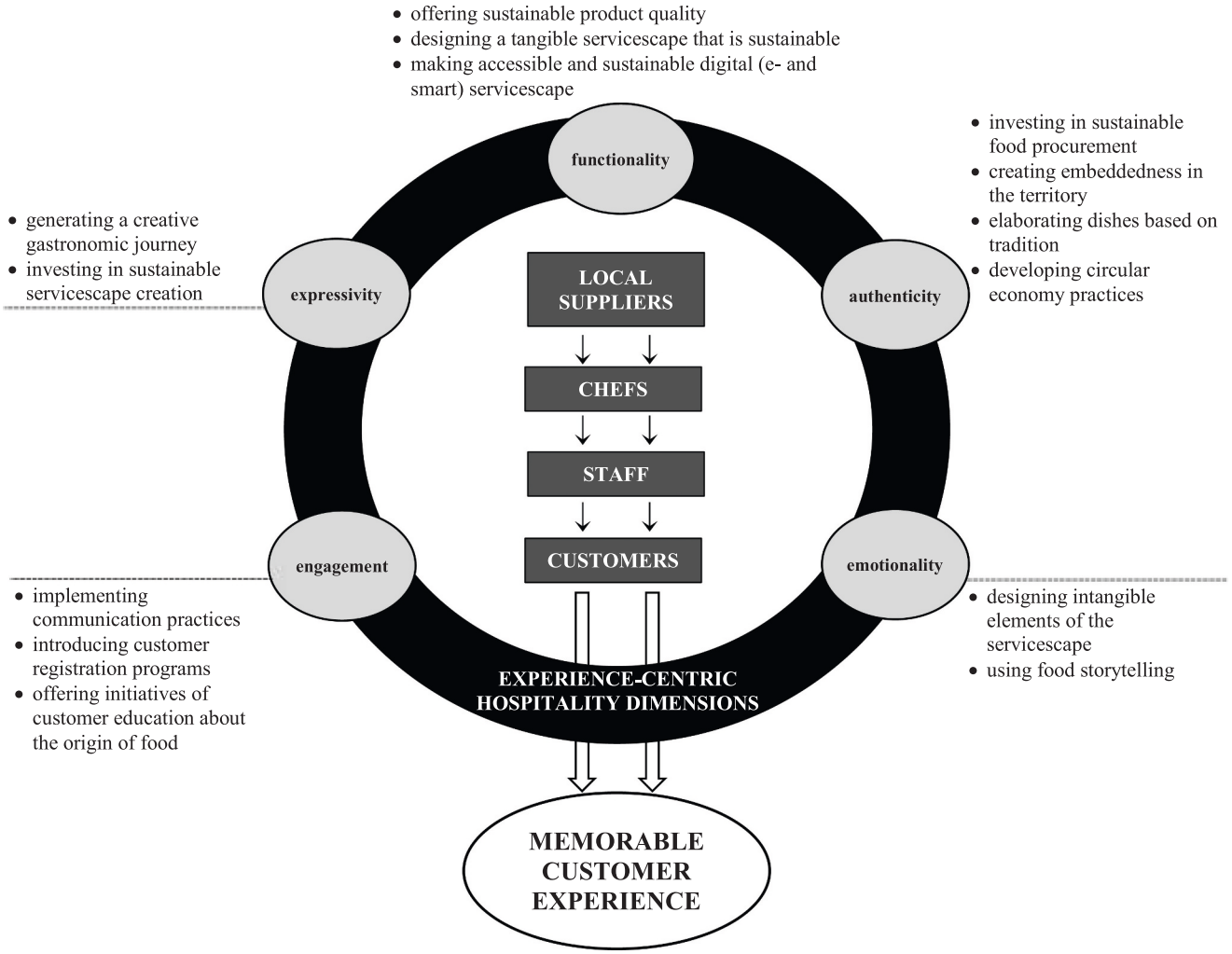


Fig. 3. A model of memorable customer experience design in upscale restaurants: the contribution of sustainable practices.

4.2. The role of sustainable practices in designing memorable customer experience in upscale restaurants: towards a conceptual model

The sustainable practices adopted by MGSR to improve the memorability of CX can be classified according to their contribution to different dimensions of CX (Fig. 3). The findings show that restaurants adopt sustainable practices that contribute to creating memorable CX through different experience providers, such as local suppliers, chefs, staff, and customers. Thus, memorable CX results from a circular process that integrates several sustainable practices within the dimensions of hospitality experience (i.e., functionality, authenticity, emotionality, engagement, and expressivity). For example, restaurant managers and chefs highlighted the value of offering menus based on high-quality, seasonal, organic, and local ingredients purchased from nearby suppliers. These ingredients are used to create experimental menus with traditional dishes that combine innovation with local culture. This sustainable business practice, which contributes to memorability by enhancing the functionality dimension of CX, is developed with the key collaboration between chefs and local suppliers. The narration of stories regarding the origins of ingredients, their sustainable sourcing, and their link with the local culture reinforces the memorability of CX by emphasizing the authenticity dimension while stimulating emotions through storytelling techniques and facilitating engagement. In this storytelling, collaboration between chefs and staff is essential. In addition, some restaurants also adopt sustainable practices to engage with the broader community, for instance, by organizing customer education initiatives for children. Finally, creativity, for example, in preparing original high-quality, sustainable dishes or in adopting sustainable fashion uniforms, contributes to memorability by enhancing the expressivity dimension of CX.

5. Discussion

The results of this study shed light that MGSRs integrate sustainability practices in CX design in order to create memorable CX and, therefore, increase business competitiveness (e.g., Angeloni, 2023; Batat, 2021; Hwang and Seo, 2016; Kim and Ritchie, 2014; McColl et al., 2022).

Unlike past studies, this research provides empirical evidence of the hospitality dimensions proposed in the theoretical model by Kandampully and colleagues (2023), i.e., functionality, authenticity, emotionality, and engagement. In this regard, this study identifies the sustainable practices adopted by MGRSs to enhance the memorability of CX for each dimension of the hospitality CX. Indeed, some contents of these dimensions have already been examined in previous studies, but the scholars have studied them separately and not in an organic conceptual model – as this research differently attempts to do. In addition, this study proposes empirical-based examples of how sustainable practices contribute to each of the CX dimensions proposed in the literature. In this reference, in line with past studies (Ha and Jang, 2013; Khan, 2020), the interviewees suggest providing customers with dining encounters based on high product quality and elaborate menus in an elegant and refined atmosphere, confirming that functional design of the different elements of the physical servicescape is fundamental to create memorable CX (Fernandes et al., 2015). From this perspective, this research further outlines investing in digital servicescape, making an accessible and usable e-servicescape, and developing smart servicescape. In addition, each memorable CX must be authentic: this research confirms the relevance of offering typical and excellent products based on local tradition (Batat, 2021; Bonfanti et al., 2023; Hoang and Suleri, 2021). No less significant is generating emotions by designing intangible elements of the servicescape, as more scholars argued (Bastiaansen et al., 2019; Horng and Hsu, 2021; Lin, 2022; Souki et al., 2023), and engaging customers by developing relationships with chefs, maître d'oeuvres, and waitpersons with a welcoming social servicescape in which also to offer the unexpected that, as it is known in hospitality management literature (Goolaup et al., 2018; Şahin et al., 2021), surprise by creating memories for a long time.

Sustainable practices can also contribute to the memorability of CX through expressivity, which emerges from this research as an original and crucial dimension of hospitality CX. It highlights the importance of providing customers with a creative gastronomic journey through the innovative flair of chefs. Specifically, expressivity originates from the willingness, creative flair, talent, and study of chefs (and their teams) to mix, contaminate, and unite different traditions and cultures in something new and different that is brought to the table to be remembered positively. Expressivity in upscale restaurants such as MGSRs includes the creation of dishes with accents and fusions of great intensity to the sight and palate based on a biological, biodynamic, and vegetarian food choice, respecting the environment and the health of guests and aiming to limit waste as much as possible. This offering approach addresses the customers' cultural and emotional needs by aligning with the growing demand for dining experiences that are innovative, deeply engaging, and, at the same time, ethical (e.g., Japutra et al., 2022).

The MGSRs examined for this study are thus investing in multiple sustainable practices because they believe it is important to engage in a sustainability perspective to mitigate their environmental impact, as previous scholars argued (Huang and Hall, 2023; Madanaguli et al., 2022; Raab et al., 2018). In this regard, the findings reinforce the results by Huang and colleagues (2023), who analyzed the website content of 355 MGSRs by highlighting the efforts of these restaurants not only to reduce food waste and disposables but also to implement further sustainable practices such as the development of circular economy processes. Unlike Huang et al. (2023), this study does not provide empirical evidence for sustainable practices aimed at energy efficiency and reducing greenhouse gas emissions. Additionally, while Huang et al. (2023) examine all the sustainable practices adopted in general by MGSRs, our study focuses only on those that actively contribute to the memorability of CX. To this purpose, a variety of stakeholders (local suppliers, chefs, staff, and customers) are involved in the hospitality experience and the implementation of sustainable practices, thus extending the importance of co-creation for memorable CX in upscale restaurants (Shulga and Busser, 2020; Ribeiro et al., 2023).

6. Theoretical and practical implications

6.1. Implications to the theory

The findings of this study provide an original contribution to the open debate in the hospitality industry, especially upscale restaurants, about the creation of memorable CX (Cao et al., 2019; Goolaup et al., 2018; Horng and Hsu, 2021; Souki et al., 2023) and the adoption of sustainable practices (Huang et al., 2023; Madanaguli et al., 2022; Raab et al., 2018; Riva et al., 2022; Tasca et al., 2022). Specifically, our study combines and extends these two streams of research, which have traditionally been studied separately, in a unified theoretical model.

In terms of combination, while past research has focused on memorable CX creation and the adoption of sustainable practices in MGSRs distinctly – except for very few studies on the link between CX and environmental sustainability (Calza et al., 2023; Mihardjo et al., 2019; Moliner et al., 2019) –, this research provides theoretical and practical evidence that memorable CX in upscale restaurants can be examined from a sustainable perspective and framed via a model that includes more sustainable business practices according to different experience-centric hospitality dimensions. In this sense, the findings of this study provide an original theoretical contribution by enriching memorable CX design theory through a conceptual model in which sustainable practices play a crucial role in creating memorable CX itself. This model can be further studied and broadly applied to examine how to better design memorable CX in MGSRs by investing in more sustainable practices. In line with the previous studies mentioned above, the model proposed in this research also reveals MGSRs' restaurateurs,

chefs' and staff's strong commitment to creating a memorable CX that is fundamentally sustainable from an environmental (and economic) perspective. Fewer sustainable business practices regarding the social dimension of sustainability in promoting memorable CX emerged from the analysis.

In terms of extension, this study provides new knowledge in the field of memorable CX design by applying the model's dimensions about the "soul of the hospitality experience" proposed only theoretically by Kandampully and colleagues (Kandampully et al., 2023). In this regard, this research confirms the findings of previous studies (Batat, 2021; Ha and Jang, 2013; Khan, 2020; Lee and Hwang, 2011) regarding how upscale restaurants actively strive to create lasting memories through exclusive, exciting, and extraordinary dining encounters, based on high-quality food, elaborate menus, and unique style in a refined and elegant atmosphere. At the same time, this study suggests a new and further dimension of hospitality to create memorable CX – i.e., expressivity – that can be adapted in terms of meaning within the specific research context. Although scholars have hitherto not conceptually proposed – and thus labeled – this specific dimension, literature has recognized the crucial role of chefs' creativity in proposing an experience-oriented offering in upscale restaurants (e.g., Batat, 2021; Kiatkawsin and Han, 2019).

In addition, this research supports the results of past studies (Brinkley et al., 2021; Chabert-Rios and Deale, 2016; Chin and Musa, 2021), which argued the importance of the restaurants' connections with local communities in terms of sourcing by fostering close and lasting partnerships with local farmers and suppliers to obtain shortened delivery times, product integrity, and improved cost efficiency. Furthermore, this study expands the analysis of sustainable business practices that have hitherto been carried out in literature by emphasizing the role of storytelling regarding the dishes and their ingredients and the restaurants' overall approach to sustainability. These results reveal the possibility of continuing to examine the variety of sustainability initiatives adopted by the MGSRs worldwide to improve the memorability of CX while at the same time improving upscale restaurants' environmental and social footprint (Elbelehy and Crispim, 2024).

6.2. Implications for practice

The results of this study offer several insights to practitioners. First, restaurant managers should focus on improving the memorability of CX by addressing the following dimensions of the hospitality experience: functionality, authenticity, emotionality, engagement, and expressivity. While from an environmental and social perspective, all business practices that improve upscale restaurants' environment and social footprint are valuable, from a competitive perspective, we also recommend that upscale restaurants prioritize the sustainable practices that positively affect the memorability of CX.

Second, this research highlights the importance of investing in sustainable practices such as using locally sourced and organically grown ingredients and creating local networks of proximity suppliers. For instance, MGSRs could cooperate with nearby farms and regional producers to source fresh, seasonal ingredients for their menus, thereby supporting local agriculture and guaranteeing the highest quality of ingredients. Specifically, MGSRs could offer a 'farm-to-table' experience, where diners are informed about the farms or producers supplying the ingredients for each dish. This could involve regular collaboration with local farmers to cultivate exclusive ingredients, thereby creating a direct connection between the farm and the plate. This approach allows these restaurants to distinguish themselves from other luxury establishments, whose sourcing may prioritize luxury and exclusivity over sustainability and support for local ecosystems. In addition, MGSRs can adopt advanced circular economy practices to offer unique products. For example, food waste can be transformed into new menu items like fermented beverages or broths. Emphasizing circular economy principles and offering innovative solutions for creatively repurposing food waste could allow MGSRs to differentiate themselves from other luxury dining establishments, prioritizing opulence over sustainability.

Third, storytelling emerges as a means through which upscale restaurants can enhance memorability by affecting both the emotionality and the engagement dimensions of the CX. Storytelling can involve the narration of the food, for example, by waitpersons or chefs who provide comprehensive information on the local and organic ingredients used in the kitchen. Storytelling can also be indirect, for example, through the choice of elements of the physical servicescape or the digital servicescape that are coherent with the brand image of MGSR. For example, regarding the physical servicescape, MGSRs could create eco-friendly interiors using sustainable materials like reclaimed wood or recycled fabrics. Other efforts, such as outfitting staff in uniforms made from sustainable fabrics and using energy-efficient kitchen appliances, would further demonstrate their commitment to eco-conscious practices. With regard to digital servicescape, digital platforms could be used to share the story behind each dish's origin. Additionally, MGSRs could actively promote their environmental initiatives on social media, offering behind-the-scenes content that showcases their sustainability journey. Unlike other luxury dining restaurants, these elements narrate and reinforce the restaurant's brand identity regarding sustainability.

Fourth, the results of this research encourage restaurant managers to continue strategically integrating sustainable practices into operations management to enhance memorable CX design and increase the competitive advantage of MGSRs. This study suggests undertaking several activities, such as staff training, customer education, and stakeholder engagement. From the training viewpoint, restaurant managers need to equip their staff with the necessary knowledge and skills regarding product and service quality and experience quality. In line with previous studies (e.g., Baratta et al., 2022; Bonfanti et al., 2023), training should further prepare staff in terms of knowledge of local culture and traditions and sustainable practices adopted (e.g., sustainable sourcing, eco-friendly cooking techniques, and methods to reduce waste), as well as the development of skills about communication and interaction with customers to make customers aware of being part of a unique experience. Not only must chefs love their cuisine and know the food and raw materials that make each dish unique, but also the staff must be trained to give customers a vivid and memorable memory to customers during the room service. Restaurant managers can also invest in customer education activities to effectively inform their customers about their sustainable practices. As a result, customers can enjoy further memorable CX after understanding, evaluating, and appreciating the restaurant's sustainability efforts. In addition, restaurants can offer chef-led workshops or cooking classes to offer educational experiences about sustainable cooking or guided tours to local farms to learn the value of food procurement. From the stakeholder engagement viewpoint, restaurant managers should develop relationships with multiple stakeholders to create a memorable CX. This research highlights the importance of engaging local suppliers, chefs, staff, and customers in the activities of MGSRs to co-create memorable CX and provide customers with unique dishes and experiences that reflect a unique culinary heritage. In addition, they should provide conditions for a positive working atmosphere and harmonious cooperation between chefs and staff to give customers a memorable experience. Finally, restaurants can engage customers in the menu development process through surveys, tastings, or focus groups to gain valuable insights into customer preferences and adapt their offerings.

7. Conclusions

This study investigated the contribution of sustainable practices to memorable CX creation by empirically examining the context of MGSRs. Using a qualitative methodology, this research highlights that sustainable practices performed by MGSRs contribute to memorable CX design. More precisely, it reveals that these two topics - previously studied separately in hospitality management literature - can be combined in a

framework showing a circular process that integrates the sustainable practices implemented by MGSRs with the dimensions of hospitality experience (functionality, authenticity, emotionality, engagement, and expressivity). In this process, the partnerships developed between and among local suppliers, chefs, staff, and customers play a fundamental role in creating memorable CX. This study contributes to the hospitality management literature, especially in upscale restaurants, by proposing a conceptual model of memorable CX creation that combines sustainable practices according to experience-centered hospitality dimensions. In addition, practical implications for MGSRs' managers are advised to continue to compete successfully.

This study has limitations that offer the opportunity to undertake several future research avenues. First, the number of restaurant managers interviewed is low compared to the total of MGSRs located worldwide. Future studies could extend the sample to other restaurants and more staff members within each restaurant, as well as local suppliers and customers. Collecting different perspectives could provide a broader conceptualization of the memorable CX design. Second, this paper is based on a qualitative cross-sectional study. Future studies could include longitudinal research and a quantitative approach to measure the contribution of sustainable practices to memorable CX. Finally, this study investigated the context of MGSRs. Future research could include other non-green-star upscale restaurants that adopt sustainable practices to examine possible similarities and differences in comparison to the results of this research. Third, this study did not consider the customers' perspective. Future research could investigate how customers evaluate the sustainable business practices of upscale restaurants in terms of CX memorability. In addition, it would be interesting to explore potential differences in perceptions between local customers (e.g., residents) and tourists. With specific regard to tourists, researchers could explore the role of sustainable practices in influencing tourists' choices throughout their travel experience.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Vania Vigolo: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Software. **Giovanna Bagnato:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Methodology, Investigation, Data curation. **Angelo Bonfanti:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Methodology, Conceptualization.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare no conflict of interest.

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